

5 Tension Habits

You Don't Even Notice You Have

A guide to finding ease in the moments you repeat every single day

Most people come to the Alexander Technique because something hurts, or because they're exhausted in a way that sleep doesn't fix.

What they discover is something simpler — and stranger — than they expected: they've been working too hard at everything. Not just the big things. The small things. The invisible things. The things they've been doing the same way, with the same unnecessary effort, for twenty or thirty or fifty years.

This guide introduces five everyday moments that are secretly full of tension. You'll recognise all of them. And once you do, you can't un-see them — which is exactly where change begins.

"How you do anything is how you do everything."

Christopher Neville

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Habit 1

Brushing Your Teeth

It's one of the first things you do every morning — and you've probably been doing it the same way for decades. Take a moment right now and imagine yourself brushing. How hard are you gripping the toothbrush? Is your jaw clenched? Are you hunched over the sink, neck compressed, arm working harder than it needs to?

This tiny, automatic routine is a perfect window into how much unnecessary effort we bring to everyday life. The Alexander Technique calls this *excess tension* — muscle work that doesn't serve the task. Two minutes of daily over-gripping, repeated across a lifetime, becomes background noise you stop noticing. Until now.

◆ TRY THIS

Tomorrow morning, pause before you start. Notice your grip on the brush. Can you lighten it by 30%? Let your elbow stay easy. Let your neck stay free. The teeth still get clean — and you've just started your day with awareness instead of autopilot.

Habit 2

Drinking a Glass of Water

Drinking water seems about as simple as it gets. And yet — watch how most people do it. The head cranes forward to meet the glass. The shoulders lift slightly. The jaw tightens as if bracing for something. A whole-body micro-bracing for a sip.

What you do most often matters most. If you drink eight glasses of water a day and each one comes with a small surge of unnecessary tension, that's eight daily reminders to your nervous system that the world requires effort and guardedness. The good news: it's also eight opportunities to practice something different.

◆ TRY THIS

Next time you reach for a glass, let the glass come up to you rather than going down to meet it. Keep your neck soft. Notice whether your shoulders crept up — and let them drop. The water tastes the same. You feel a little more like yourself.

Habit 3

Driving

The car might be where you spend more tense, concentrated time than almost anywhere else. White-knuckling the wheel at 10-and-2. Chin jutting forward toward the windshield. Shoulders braced as if absorbing impact that hasn't happened. The body treating a commute like a combat situation.

Applying the Alexander Technique to driving is, honestly, magical. When you allow your back to lengthen and widen against the seat, when you let the headrest actually support your head, when your hands rest on the wheel with enough grip to steer but no more — the whole experience changes. Less frustration. Less fatigue. You arrive somewhere and don't feel like you survived the journey.

◆ TRY THIS

At your next red light, do a quick scan. Where are you holding? Soften your hands. Let your back settle into the seat. Feel the seat supporting you — you don't have to hold yourself up. Notice how the road looks different when your eyes aren't hardened by tension.

Habit 4

Sitting at Your Desk

Hours of forward-head posture, compressed lower back, one shoulder higher than the other, jaw set, breath shallow. The modern desk setup is almost perfectly designed to teach the body that sitting requires strain.

The screen pulls you toward it like a magnet, and the rest of you follows — collapsing forward in tiny increments until by 3pm you're a entirely different shape than you were at 9am. This isn't about 'good posture' in the rigid, military sense. It's about learning to sit with support and ease — your spine doing what spines are actually built to do.

◆ TRY THIS

Right now, as you read this: is your head balanced lightly on top of your spine, or has it drifted forward? Let it float back — not yanked back, just released upward. Notice if your lower back softens against the chair. Take one easy breath. That's the technique, in miniature.

Habit 5

Interacting With People

This is the big one. Social tension is so woven into daily life that most people carry it constantly without realising it's optional. Before a difficult conversation, the chest tightens. In a crowded room, the shoulders armour up. Even a friendly exchange at the checkout can involve more physical bracing than the situation warrants.

The body doesn't distinguish well between 'actually dangerous' and 'socially uncomfortable.' It just activates. And when that activation becomes the baseline, you're spending enormous energy just existing around other people.

If you can soften even a little — come into a conversation with a neck that's free, a breath that's easy, feet that actually feel the ground — the quality of that interaction changes. People feel it. You feel it.

◆ TRY THIS

Before your next conversation, take one breath and let your feet find the floor. You don't need to do anything dramatic. Just arrive. Be in the room before you try to perform in it.

So — What Now?

Noticing is the whole first step. You don't have to fix anything yet. Just start catching yourself — at the sink, in the car, at your desk, in a conversation — and asking: *Is this much effort actually necessary here?*

Often, the answer is no. And in that moment of recognition, something softens. That softening is the Alexander Technique working.

These five habits are just the beginning. The same principle applies to everything: the way you stand waiting for coffee, the way you hold your phone, the way you brace before a difficult email. Ease is available in all of it.

Ready to go deeper?

I work with people one-on-one to bring this kind of awareness into their daily life — in a way that actually sticks. Lessons are gentle, practical, and surprisingly enjoyable.

Get in touch or book a lesson:

www.useyourselfwell.com

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